

Bipin Rawat had described the islands as "unsinkable aircraft carriers"; in an October 2021 interview with INDIA TODAY, he said fighters operating from the islands had none of the vulnerabilities of aircraft carriers, which were expensive, vulnerable to detection and could be targeted by an adversary. (The concept of an 'unsinkable aircraft carrier' originated in World War II, when the US built up a series of island airbases in the Pacific to target mainland Japan.)

This view is echoed by military analyst Rear Admiral Raja Menon, who recommends the islands be made the fulcrum of India's strategy to counter China's maritime buildup and offset Beijing's overland pressure on New Delhi. In an independent paper submitted to the government last month, he writes that upgraded Chinese infrastructure in Tibet—from expressways to bullet trains—allows the PLA to swiftly move around smaller overall numbers of acclimatised troops, giving it the ability to overwhelm Indian forces at any point along the boundary. Creating an 'eastern battlespace' at the Malacca Straits would give India offensive options at sea, allowing the country to throttle Chinese maritime commerce and force incoming PLA naval units through a choke point where they could be targeted.

In recent years, contingency planning like this has been going on in several countries threatened by the rise of a belligerent China. In September 2021 the US, UK and Australia announced a trilateral security pact—AUKUS—to act as a force multiplier in the Indo-Pacific. On September 24, US president Joe Biden hosted the first in-person security dialogue of the Quad Leaders' Summit in the White House, hosting PM Narendra Modi, Japan PM Yoshihide Suga and Australia PM Scott Morrison.

Emphasising the strategic location of the A&N Islands, Sujan Chinoy, director general of the MP-IDSA (Manohar Parrikar Institute of Defence Studies and Analyses) recommends opening them up to the Quad's navies. In a June 2020 paper, he also noted that a 'combination of economic and strategic factors has significantly enhanced the strategic salience of the Bay of Bengal and its littorals'. "The A&N Islands are at the intersection of the Indian Ocean and the South China Sea, and further to the Pacific Ocean, an important fulcrum of the strategic concept of the Indo-Pacific," he says.

A SLOW AWAKENING

The strategic potential of the A&N Islands has been known for decades. They flank the Bay of Bengal, where India's growing fleet of ballistic missile-carrying nuclear powered submarines (SSBNs) operates from. The Andaman Sea is a sanctuary from where Indian SSBNs can target both its nuclear-armed adversaries in a retaliatory second-strike. In the late 1990s, navy chief Admiral Vishnu Bhagwat had called for an upgrade of the region's command and control system, for Fortress Andaman to be converted into a Far Eastern Command, led by a navy flag officer with deputies from the army and air force. However, the proposal was shelved, and in 2001, the island was put under India's only tri-services command—the Andaman and Nicobar Command (ANC). It is a tiny version of what the defence ministry hopes to reorganise India's armed forces into—five integrated theatre commands